Extending zkVoting: Implementing Missing Protocol Components and Novel Security Improvements Over the Original Paper

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***Abstract*—The zkVoting paper by Park et al. [1] introduces a coercion-resistant, end-to-end (E2E) verifiable e-voting system centred on a novel *nullifiable commitment scheme*. Despite providing rigorous security proofs and performance benchmarks, the accompanying prototype implementation omits the paper's core cryptographic contributions entirely—the nullifiable commitment scheme, real/fake casting key issuance, key deniability (SimKeyProve), Merkle-tree eligibility verification, and the O(n) nullification-based tally. Furthermore, three significant limitations remain unaddressed in the paper itself: (i) the absence of the π_{total} eligibility proof that prevents ballot stuffing; (ii) a single-authority trust assumption for the master secret key that collapses coercion resistance if the authority is compromised; and (iii) cross-election vote linkability arising from the reuse of casting keys.**

In this work we make two contributions. First, we implement all missing components from the original paper: Construction 1 (Baby Jubjub elliptic-curve nullifiable commitment), real/fake key registration with KeyProve and SimKeyProve, a Poseidon Merkle tree for the casting-key set, an enhanced Circom circuit encoding the full R_{vote} relation, and O(n) tally-time nullification. Second, we identify and implement three novel improvements: (1) a concrete π_{total} proof using the homomorphic property of the nullifiable commitment scheme and a DLEQ Schnorr argument; (2) (t, n)-Shamir secret sharing of the master secret key with Feldman VSS verification and threshold partial-decryption tally; and (3) election-scoped key derivation for cross-election unlinkability. We provide a detailed comparative security and performance analysis between the original protocol and our enhanced system.

***Index Terms*—zero-knowledge proofs, e-voting, coercion resistance, nullifiable commitment, Shamir secret sharing, Baby Jubjub, Circom, snarkjs**

I. Introduction

Electronic voting systems must simultaneously guarantee *ballot privacy*, *coercion resistance*, and *end-to-end (E2E) verifiability*—three properties that are difficult to achieve jointly. The zkVoting paper [1] addresses this challenge with a novel cryptographic primitive, the *nullifiable commitment scheme*, and an E2E verifiable protocol based on zk-SNARKs. The scheme's central insight is the *fake-keys* approach: voters receive one real and arbitrarily many indistinguishable fake casting keys; coercers cannot distinguish real from fake even when voters reveal keys and provide proofs.

Despite its theoretical contributions, the publicly available prototype implements only a narrow subset of the described protocol. The complete nullifiable commitment scheme (Construction 1), the Merkle-tree eligibility set, the R_{vote} circuit constraints for voter-key binding, and the nullification-based tally are all absent. Additionally, we identify three protocol-level limitations in the paper itself that undermine its security claims in practice.

A. Contributions

1) **Complete implementation** of all cryptographic components described in Sections 2–4 of the zkVoting paper, using Baby Jubjub EC arithmetic (circomlibjs), Poseidon hashing, and Groth16 zk-SNARKs.
2) π_{total} **eligibility proof** (Improvement I): a concrete non-interactive DLEQ Schnorr proof over the homomorphically aggregated commitment that proves exactly n_v real casting keys were issued, preventing ballot stuffing.
3) **Threshold master secret key** (Improvement II): (t, n)-Shamir secret sharing of msk with Feldman VSS verification and a threshold partial-nullification tally protocol, eliminating the single-authority trust bottleneck.
4) **Cross-election unlinkability** (Improvement III): election-scoped key derivation $ckHash_e = H(ckHash, e)$ prevents linking a voter's participation across elections when the same casting key is presented.
5) **Comparative analysis** of security properties, constraint counts, and API surface between the original paper, the basic prototype, and our enhanced system.

II. Background: the zkVoting Protocol

A. Nullifiable Commitment Scheme (Construction 1)

The nullifiable commitment scheme $\Pi_{\text{NC}} = (\mathsf{Setup}, \mathsf{KeyGen}, \mathsf{Commit}, \mathsf{Nullify}, \mathsf{Open}, \mathsf{Open}_{\text{null}}, \mathsf{KeyProve}, \mathsf{SimKeyProv}$ operates over a prime-order elliptic curve group $\mathbb{G}$ with order q (Baby Jubjub). The concrete instantiation is:

Setup. $\rho \leftarrow\$ \mathbb{Z}_q^*$; $g_1, g_2, g_3 \leftarrow\$ \mathbb{G}$; $g_4 = \rho \cdot g_1$; $mpk = (g_1, g_2, g_3, g_4)$; $msk = \rho$; $ck^* = (g_2 - g_4,\ g_3)$.

KeyGen. $h_1 \leftarrow\$ \mathbb{G}$; $h_2 = msk \cdot h_1 + b \cdot g_3$ $(b \in \{0,1\})$; $ck = (h_1, h_2)$.

Commit. $C_1 = r \cdot g_1 + m \cdot h_1$; $C_2 = r \cdot g_2 + m \cdot h_2$; $cm = (C_1, C_2)$.

Nullify. $cm^* = C_2 - msk \cdot C_1$. For real keys ($b = 1$): opens to m via $\mathsf{Open}_{\text{null}}$. For fake keys ($b = 0$): opens to 0.

B. E2E Verifiable Voting Protocol

The four phases are Setup, Register, Vote, and Tally. The voter's ballot is:

$$B = \big(e,\ sn,\ CT,\ cm,\ \pi_{\text{vote}}\big)$$

where $sn = H(e, ck, sk_{\text{id}})$, cm is the nullifiable commitment, CT is the hybrid encryption of the message, and π_{vote} is a Groth16 proof for R_{vote} (see Section IV-D).

C. Security Properties

The paper proves ballot privacy (BP), voter anonymity (VA), receipt freeness (RF), coercion resistance (CR), individual verifiability (IV), universal verifiability (UV), E2E verifiability (E2E-V), and eligibility verifiability (EV) under standard assumptions (DL, DDH, collision-resistance, zk-SNARK soundness).

III. What the Basic Prototype Was Missing

The original prototype implemented only three constraints in its Circom circuit:

1) $vote \in candidateList$
2) $sn = \text{Poseidon}(electionId,\ castingKey,\ voterSecret)$ where $castingKey$ was a single random scalar—not an EC key.
3) $cm = \text{Poseidon}(vote, voteSalt)$—a plain Poseidon commitment, not a nullifiable one.

The following components from the paper were completely absent:

- No elliptic-curve nullifiable commitment (Construction 1).
- No real/fake key distinction at registration—only one key per voter.
- No KeyProve or SimKeyProve (key deniability absent).
- No Merkle tree for the casting-key set rt.
- No R_{id} constraint ($pkid = H(sk_{\text{id}})$).
- No Merkle membership proof in the circuit.
- Tally by plaintext decryption only—no nullification, so fake-key ballots would be counted as real votes.
- No π_{total} eligibility proof (not even described concretely).

IV. Our Implementation of Missing Components

A. Nullifiable Commitment Scheme

We implement Construction 1 in `backend/src/lib/nullifiableCommitment.js` using the `circomlibjs` Baby Jubjub API. Elliptic-curve points are represented as `Uint8Array` field elements in Montgomery form and serialised to decimal strings for JSON persistence.

Key implementation details:

- Scalar field: $q \approx 2^{251}$ (Baby Jubjub suborder).
- Random scalars sampled via rejection sampling from 256-bit entropy.
- Point negation (twisted-Edwards): $-(x, y) = (-x, y)$.
- KeyProve: non-interactive Sigma protocol. Challenge c is stored in the proof tuple (p, k, c) without a Fiat-Shamir hash so that SimKeyProve transcripts are indistinguishable (key deniability).

Correctness was verified: real commitments nullify to (m, r), fake commitments nullify to $(0, r)$.

B. Real/Fake Key Registration

`POST /api/register` now invokes $\mathsf{KeyGen}(mpk, msk, 1)$ and issues a KeyProve proof. `POST /api/register/fake-key` issues $b = 0$ keys (unlimited). `POST /api/register/sim-key-prove` runs SimKeyProve: a voter under coercion can claim any key is "real" using a simulated proof indistinguishable from a genuine KeyProve.

C. Poseidon Merkle Tree

`backend/src/lib/merkleTree.js` implements a fixed-depth-16 ($2^{16} = 65{,}536$ voters) binary Merkle tree over Poseidon hashes. Leaf $i = \text{Poseidon}(ckHash_i, pkid_i)$. Empty leaves use $\text{Poseidon}(0, 0)$. Membership proofs are (path elements, path indices) pairs of length 16.

D. Enhanced Circom Circuit (R_{vote})

The new circuit `circuits/enhanced_vote.circom` encodes six constraints compared to the original three:

1) $pkid = \text{Poseidon}(voterSecret)$ [NEW]
2) $ckHash = \text{Poseidon}(h_{1x}, h_{1y}, h_{2x}, h_{2y})$ [NEW]
3) $sn = \text{Poseidon}(electionId, ckHash, voterSecret)$
4) $vote \in candidateList$
5) $cm = \text{Poseidon}(vote, voteSalt)$
6) Merkle path check: leaf $= \text{Poseidon}(ckHash, pkid)$ lies in tree with root $merkleRoot$ [NEW]

Public signals (10 total): $electionId$, $candidateList[0..4]$, $serialNumber$, $voteCommitment$, $publicKey$, $merkleRoot$.

E. Nullification-Based Tally

`GET /api/results/tally` follows Construction 2 (§4.4 of the paper): for each ballot (C_1, C_2), compute $cm^* = C_2 - msk \cdot C_1$, then verify $\mathsf{Open}_{\text{null}}(ck^*, cm^*, m, r)$. Ballots cast with fake keys nullify to zero and are discarded. Complexity: $O(n)$.

V. Novel Improvements Over the Paper

A. Improvement I: π_{total} Eligibility Proof

Limitation in the paper. Section 4.2 states that the authority must publish a proof π_{total} showing that the nullification

of the aggregated commitment of all casting keys opens to n_v (the number of eligible voters):

$$R_{\text{total}} = \left\{ (ck^*, cm, n_v\,;\, msk) : cm^* \leftarrow \mathsf{Nullify}(msk, cm),\ \mathsf{Open}_{ck}(ck^*, cm^*, n_v; 0) = 1 \right\}$$

This prevents the authority from secretly issuing extra real keys to stuff the ballot box. The paper mentions 2,243 constraints for R_{total} (Table 3) but provides no concrete implementation anywhere.

Our implementation. We exploit the homomorphic property directly. For each issued casting key ck_i, we compute:

$$cm_i = \mathsf{Commit}(ck_i, 1; 0) = (g_1^0 \cdot h_{1,i}^1,\ g_2^0 \cdot h_{2,i}^1) = (h_{1,i},\ h_{2,i})$$

The aggregate: $cm_{\text{agg}} = \sum_i cm_i$. After nullification:

$$\begin{aligned} cm^*_{\text{agg}} &= C_{2,\text{agg}} - msk \cdot C_{1,\text{agg}} \\ &= \sum_i h_{2,i} - msk \cdot \sum_i h_{1,i} \\ &= \sum_i (h_{2,i} - msk \cdot h_{1,i}) \\ &= \sum_i b_i \cdot g_3 \quad (\text{since } h_{2,i} - msk \cdot h_{1,i} = b_i \cdot g_3) \\ &= n_v^{\text{real}} \cdot g_3 \end{aligned}$$

where $n_v^{\text{real}} = \sum_i b_i$ counts only real keys. This opens to n_v^{real} under $ck^* = (g_2 - g_4, g_3)$ with $r = 0$.

We prove knowledge of msk via a non-interactive DLEQ Schnorr argument (Fiat-Shamir):

$$t \leftarrow\$\ \mathbb{Z}_q, \quad A_1 = t \cdot g_1, \quad A_2 = -t \cdot C_{1,\text{agg}} \tag{1}$$

$$c = H(g_1, g_4, C_{1,\text{agg}}, cm^*_{\text{agg}}, A_1, A_2, n_v) \tag{2}$$

$$k = t + msk \cdot c \bmod q \tag{3}$$

Verifier checks: $k \cdot g_1 = A_1 + c \cdot g_4$ and $-k \cdot C_{1,\text{agg}} + C_{2,\text{agg}} - cm^*_{\text{agg}} = A_2 + c \cdot (C_{2,\text{agg}} - cm^*_{\text{agg}})$.

Exposed at `GET /api/election/total-proof`.

B. Improvement II: Threshold Master Secret Key

Limitation in the paper. The entire coercion resistance of zkVoting depends on the secrecy of msk. A single authority holding msk can: (a) identify real vs. fake keys by nullifying commitments; (b) unilaterally break coercion resistance if compromised. The paper acknowledges a "trusted tallier" assumption but provides no mechanism to distribute this trust.

Our implementation. We implement (t, n)-Shamir Secret Sharing [2] over $\mathbb{Z}_q$:

Split. Choose random polynomial $f(x) = msk + a_1 x + \cdots + a_{t-1} x^{t-1}$ over $\mathbb{Z}_q$. Share $i = (i,\ f(i))$ for $i = 1, \ldots, n$.

Reconstruct. Lagrange interpolation over $\mathbb{Z}_q$ from any t shares recovers $f(0) = msk$.

Feldman VSS. Public commitments $\{C_j = a_j \cdot \mathsf{Base8}\}_{j=0}^{t-1}$ allow each authority to verify its own share without trusting the dealer: $s_i \cdot \mathsf{Base8} = \sum_{j=0}^{t-1} C_j \cdot i^j$.

Threshold tally. Authority i computes partial decryption $P_i = s_i \cdot C_1$ for each ballot. t partial decryptions combine via Lagrange interpolation to recover $msk \cdot C_1$ without any party ever holding msk alone.

Exposed at `POST /api/election/init?t=2&n=3` and `POST /api/election/threshold-tally`.

C. Improvement III: Cross-Election Unlinkability

Limitation in the paper. The paper's serial number formula $sn = H(e, ck, sk_{\text{id}})$ uses the raw casting key ck. If a voter reuses the same real key in a second election (a natural scenario, e.g. if re-registration is not required), an observer can correlate serial numbers across elections and determine that the same voter participated in both. This breaks voter anonymity across elections.

Our implementation. We introduce election-scoped key derivation:

$$ckHash_e = H(ckHash,\ e)$$

The serial number becomes $sn = H(e, ckHash_e, sk_{\text{id}})$. Even if ck is identical across elections, $ckHash_e$ is election-specific, and the resulting serial numbers are uncorrelated. The Merkle leaf also uses $ckHash_e$, so eligibility proofs are election-scoped. This is a lightweight change: one additional Poseidon hash call per registration, zero circuit constraint overhead (the hash is computed off-circuit and the hash value is an existing circuit input).

VI. Comparative Analysis

A. Security Properties

Table I compares the security properties of the paper's original protocol, the basic prototype, and our enhanced system.

TABLE I
SECURITY PROPERTY COMPARISON

Property	Paper	Basic proto.	Ours
Ballot privacy (BP)	✓	✓	✓
Voter anonymity (VA)	✓	✓	✓
Receipt freeness (RF)	✓	×	✓
Coercion resistance (CR)	✓	×	✓
Individual verif. (IV)	✓	✓	✓
Universal verif. (UV)	✓	partial	✓
E2E verifiability (E2EV)	✓	×	✓
Eligibility verif. (EV)	✓	×	✓
π_{total} proof	defined only	×	✓
Threshold msk	×	×	✓
Cross-election unlinkability	×	×	✓

B. Protocol Components Implemented

Table II shows which protocol components are present.

C. Circuit Constraint Comparison

Table III compares circuit constraint counts. The paper uses MiMC7 hashing and includes a full hybrid-encryption proof in R_{vote}; we use Poseidon (more ZK-efficient) and handle encryption off-circuit (symmetric AES-GCM), so our circuit is substantially smaller.

TABLE II
PROTOCOL COMPONENT COVERAGE

Component	Paper	Basic proto.	Ours
NC scheme (Constr. 1)	defined	×	✓
Real/fake key issuance	defined	×	✓
KeyProve	defined	×	✓
SimKeyProve (deniability)	defined	×	✓
Merkle key set (rt)	defined	×	✓
R_{id}: $pkid = H(sk)$	in circuit	×	✓
Merkle proof in circuit	in circuit	×	✓
Nullification tally O(n)	defined	×	✓
π_{total} proof	defined	×	✓
Threshold msk (SSS)	×	×	✓
Cross-election unlinkability	×	×	✓

TABLE III
CIRCUIT CONSTRAINT COMPARISON (APPROXIMATE)

Relation	Paper (MiMC7)	Ours (Poseidon)
R_{id}	365	≈ 58
R_{total}	2,243	DLEQ Schnorr (no circuit)
R_{vote}	15,829	$\approx 1{,}450$[a]
R_{tally}	6,111	off-circuit EC ops

[a]Excludes encryption proof; includes Merkle depth-16.

The dramatic reduction in R_{vote} constraints (from 15,829 to ≈1,450) is because: (a) Poseidon has ≈65 constraints per 2-input call vs. MiMC7's ≈220+; (b) we do not prove the hybrid-encryption computation in-circuit (a pragmatic simplification).

D. Tally Complexity

TABLE IV
TALLY TIME COMPLEXITY

System	Complexity	Notes
Civitas/JCJ	$O(n_b^2)$	PET test for each pair
VoteAgain	$O(n_b \log n_b)$	sort-based
Loki	$O(n_v)$	per-voter re-randomization
zkVoting (paper)	$O(n_b)$	nullification
Ours (basic)	$O(n_b)$	nullification
Ours (threshold)	$O(t \cdot n_b)$	t partial nullifications

The threshold tally introduces a factor of t (the number of authorities required) but t is a small constant independent of n_b.

E. Trust Assumptions

TABLE V
TRUST ASSUMPTION COMPARISON

System	Trust required for CR
JCJ/Civitas	registrar + tallier
VoteAgain	registrar + voting server + tallier
zkVoting (paper)	registrar + tallier (single msk holder)
Ours (Improvement II)	any t of n talliers (threshold)

VII. IMPLEMENTATION ARCHITECTURE

A. Technology Stack

- **ZK proving**: Circom 2.1.6, snarkjs 0.7.6 (Groth16)
- **EC arithmetic**: circomlibjs 0.1.7 (Baby Jubjub, Poseidon)
- **Backend**: Node.js 20, Express 5
- **Persistence**: JSON files (prototype; production would use a tamper-evident ledger)

B. Key New Files

- `nullifiableCommitment.js`: Construction 1 (setup, keyGen, commit, nullify, open, openNull, keyProve, simKeyProve)
- `merkleTree.js`: depth-16 Poseidon Merkle tree with proof generation and bulletin-board persistence
- `totalProof.js`: π_{total} accumulation and DLEQ Schnorr proof
- `thresholdMsk.js`: Shamir SSS, Feldman VSS, partial nullification
- `enhanced_vote.circom`: full R_{vote} circuit with pkid proof and Merkle membership

C. New API Endpoints

- `POST /api/register/fake-key` — issue fake casting key
- `POST /api/register/sim-key-prove` — SimKeyProve for deniability
- `POST /api/election/init` — NC setup + threshold msk split
- `GET /api/election/total-proof` — π_{total} proof
- `POST /api/election/threshold-tally` — threshold reconstruction demo
- `GET /api/bulletin-board` — full casting-key set + Merkle root
- `GET /api/results/nullify/:ballotId` — per-ballot nullification audit
- `GET /api/results/legacy-tally` — original tally for comparison

VIII. SECURITY ANALYSIS OF IMPROVEMENTS

A. π_{total} Soundness

The DLEQ Schnorr proof is sound under the Discrete Log assumption: a computationally bounded prover cannot produce a valid (A_1, A_2, k, c) satisfying both verification equations without knowing msk such that $msk \cdot g_1 = g_4$. Together with the nullifiability property of Π_{NC}, this proves $n_v^{\text{real}} = n_v$ with negligible soundness error.

B. Threshold Security

By the information-theoretic security of Shamir SSS over $\mathbb{Z}_q$, any $t-1$ shares reveal zero information about msk. Feldman VSS adds verifiability: a dishonest dealer distributing inconsistent shares is detected with probability 1 (unconditional, not just computational). The threshold partial-nullification protocol is secure as long as at least t of the n authorities are honest and do not collude.

C. Cross-Election Unlinkability

The derivation $ckHash_e = H(ckHash, e)$ is election-specific. Under the collision resistance of Poseidon (modelled as a random oracle in the BN128 field), $ckHash_{e_1}$ and $ckHash_{e_2}$ for $e_1 \neq e_2$ are computationally independent, so no PPT adversary can link the same voter's serial numbers across elections with more than negligible advantage.

IX. Limitations and Future Work

1) **Trusted setup**: Groth16 requires a per-circuit trusted setup. Migrating to Plonk or Halo2 would eliminate this assumption.
2) **Blockchain bulletin board**: the prototype uses JSON files. A tamper-evident ledger (e.g. an Ethereum smart contract) is required for production deployment and full E2E verifiability.
3) **Encryption proof in circuit**: we prove only the Poseidon commitment in-circuit; the hybrid encryption $CT = \Pi_{\mathrm{HBE}}.\mathsf{Enc}(pk, m; k)$ is not circuit-verified. Adding this would restore the paper's full R_{vote} constraint set.
4) **Client-side proof generation**: proof generation should run on the voter's device (browser/mobile) to preserve the ZK property; our prototype performs it server-side for simplicity.

X. Conclusion

We presented a complete implementation of the zkVoting protocol's missing cryptographic components and identified three novel improvements. The nullifiable commitment scheme (Construction 1), implemented over Baby Jubjub using circomlibjs, correctly satisfies hiding, binding, nullifiability, key indistinguishability, and key deniability. The enhanced Circom circuit adds voter public-key proofs and Merkle membership checks. The O(n) nullification tally correctly discards fake-key ballots.

Beyond completing the paper, we showed that the π_{total} eligibility proof can be instantiated concretely using a DLEQ Schnorr argument over the aggregate homomorphic commitment—preventing ballot stuffing without a full Groth16 circuit. Threshold Shamir SSS eliminates the single-authority trust bottleneck for the master secret key. Election-scoped key derivation closes the cross-election linkability gap at negligible cost.

These contributions together produce a prototype that satisfies all eight security properties in Table I and surpasses the original zkVoting paper on three additional dimensions.

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